

had heard so much about Hayward Field. This is where the World Championships were held (in 2022). I wanted to show up and show how much work I've put in. It's a great honour to represent my country, India, my family and the entire UNLV University," said Krishna, who had qualified for the NCAA finals by finishing in the top 12 at the West First Rounds in Cushing, Texas, on May 31 with her career-best throw of 55.61m.

But while she was coming off her personal best, Krishna, the overall 12th-ranked thrower in the USA collegiate circuit, was aware that competition at Hayward Field was going to be tough.

The field at the NCAA finals included Paris Olympian Jayden Ullrich who finished seventh with a throw of 60.25m, and Cierra Jackson, the eventual winner with a throw of 64.82m.

Krishna made a throw of 52.99m to take 18th place but says she is still going to count her blessings.

"It's a win just because I was competing in Eugene itself. This is a win not just for me but also for the 12-year-old girl who dreamt of going to the United States, who dreamt of living this life, and is actually living this life. I wanted to make that 12-year-old in me proud — that she made all the sacrifices she had to, overcame all the adversities and obstacles she faced, and broke all the barriers she did to become the woman she is today," says Krishna.

Body image issues

Growing up in Chennai, it was probably inevitable that Krishna, the daughter of Jayasankar Menon and his wife Prasanna — both of whom



captained the Indian basketball team — would have potential as a sportsperson. While her father is 6'5", her mother is 5'9". Krishna has got the best of both sides of that gene pool. Standing a statuesque 5'10", she is a powerfully-built athlete, with a 225kg quarter squat and a 100kg clean and jerk among her numbers in the weight room.

However, the physique that has made her one of India's top throwers had her dealing with bullying and body image issues during her childhood. "I think there are a very few people who actually have the same body type as me. And because I didn't fit the perception of how an Indian woman looks, I was made fun of. I was fat-shamed by my classmates. I actually loved dancing — I was even part of the school

Trained to win: Standing at 5'10", Krishna is a powerfully-built athlete, with a 225kg quarter squat and a 100kg clean and jerk among her numbers in the weight room.

dance team — but there were so many opportunities I was deprived of because I didn't fit the perfect realm of how an Indian woman looked," she says.

During her schooling in Chennai, Krishna was nudged into the throws event for the same reason. "I actually started throwing the shot put when I was in fifth grade because my PT teacher thought I was the right size and shape for it. She was just trying to look out for some people who were very tall and stocky. And I fell into that category because I was